Auwa Arrival

Last revised: 23 April 2026. Living document. Load for any launch, promotion, channel, or campaign discussion.

Why "Arrival" and Not "Launch"

The four pillars ship over 18 months: Journal live, App mid-May (friends first), Store in Year 2, Book when pre-orders justify a print run. No spike day. A cadence the brand sustains. Launches announce; arrivals are welcomed.

The Frame

1. **Brand arrival, not product launch.** Compounding, not a spike.
2. **Low-intensity cadence.** A three-to-four-day week rules out sprints. Short bursts at restart and launch moments; a calm three-a-week baseline between them.
3. **Aim wide, filter ruthlessly.** Japan interest is peak. A brand of this quality can reach 50-150K engaged followers inside three years. Every growth decision asks: *does this attract the right person, or noise?*

The Plan

Sequenced chronologically. Use as a living todo list. Complete one block before moving to the next; skip ahead when priority demands. Launch is now a few hours a day with tomorrow (Fri 24 April) full-time, then time pivots to app build and More Air productised services.

1. Get to 9 IG posts (this week and next)

The highest-leverage work. Every warm share (LinkedIn, family, peers, Darius, Ivo, Fin, Colin) compounds when the grid is full. A sparse grid undermines all of them. Aim for 9 strong posts by end of week 2 of the restart.

Friday 24 April, full-time priorities:

- **Imagen tone-adjustment pass** on the top 10-15 article hero images. Subtle tone only, no upscaling, no restyling. Side-by-side compare against originals; reject any visible AI touch. These images serve website and IG simultaneously.
- **Build out the IG content queue.** Use `/instagram:post` and `/instagram:slideshow` to prepare 6-8 posts in `social/instagram/`. Mix: Rieko character Reels from her queue, editorial slideshows from existing journal articles, atmospheric photographs, one Japanese-wisdom carousel. Queue sits ready; daily posting then becomes a copy-paste job rather than a daily-write job.
- **Book teaser upgrade.** Pick one of two options and ship Friday if time allows:
  - *(a)* Auto-play slideshow of a few inside-the-book images in the teaser image area.
  - *(b)* Button that opens a sample preview (modal or page) with a handful of book spreads to flick through.
  - Option (b) invites more engagement and reads better for Awwwards; (a) needs no new page. My lean: (b). If Friday runs short, ship (a) now and iterate to (b) next week.

Internal work that proceeds in parallel (no external touchpoints):

- **Fin DAC article draft.** His artwork of Rieko and her mum. *Draft* this week, *publish* once the grid has reached 9 posts. No external share yet.
- **Continue daily IG posts** from the queue. Figma slideshow template to be built when there's a natural slot; for now the brief from `/instagram:slideshow` is enough for Rieko to lay up slides manually.

Principle. Every external touchpoint (email to Kyoto shop, brief to Colin, LinkedIn post, family share, peer shares, Darius, Ivo, Fin reconnect) waits for the grid. Japan especially weights visible social presence as a credibility signal, and Shigefusa's sons will judge IG before anything else. A first impression you can't redo. Hold the line on all external activation until the grid is ready.

2. Warm network activation (once the grid has ~9 posts)

Gated on the grid. First impression matters more than speed of invitation. Japan especially reads social presence as a credibility signal; Shigefusa's sons, Fin's audience, and Tom's LinkedIn peers all will check the IG before engaging.

- **Kyoto knife shop email** (Rieko, in Japanese) for Shigefusa. Full approach drafted in the Shigefusa section below.
- **Tom's LinkedIn post.** Warm, proud, no ask. Template in Channel Strategy below.

- **Quiet family share.** Cary-Elwes side; brothers. Single warm note each.
- **Peer share: Brad Porter and Axel Meyer.** No ask. Honest read welcomed.
- **Darius (CMO friend).** Strategic review of the launch approach.
- **Ivo Weevers.** Launch sequencing input; he has sold an app.
- **Fin DAC.** Send him the now-published Fin article link. Warm reconnection. Collab conversation becomes natural later.
- **Colin (book promoter).** Share the book draft with the framed question: "Tell me honestly what you think, and what you'd do if this were yours." His publisher-route view is decisive.

3. Small paid spend (after 9 IG posts are live)

£200-400 test behind the Auwa face video Reel. Targeting design-conscious, Japan-interested users in UK/US/AU. Goal: lift 700 to 1,500-2,000 quality followers at restart. Gate: only begin once the grid holds nine posts so visitors arriving via ad see a complete brand, not a lonely first post.

4. Awwwards SOTD submission (target Tue 12 or Wed 13 May)

Full checklist in CLAUDE.md under AWWWARDS READINESS. Submission gates, all must be true:

1. At least one SOTD teaser upgrade shipped (Book minimum).
2. Nine strong IG posts live. Quality gate, not count gate.
3. Noindex audit passed (`/home-1` , `/brand` , `/instagram` , `/book/1` , `/book/2` all carry `robots: { index: false, follow: false }` and live in `robots.ts` disallow).
4. Photography credit pass done (every editorial image credits Tom).

Miss any gate, push submission one week. Never submit to beat a date.

Submission inputs pre-drafted. See Awwwards Prep section below.

5. App built, friends-released (mid-May)

Share with Tom's warm network and early IG followers who've expressed interest. Free tier only. Direct via DM or email. Not a public moment. Use friend feedback to refine before public release.

Public app release happens when IG has a solid following. Realistically late summer or early autumn depending on growth. No strict Q4 gate.

6. Second and third teaser upgrades (week of 28 April and week of 5 May)

App (`/app`). Mocked Kokoro card below the hero: gradient background in a Yamato state colour, Auwa character centred, three lines of poetic reflection, calligraphic kō stamp. Shows the app's output without the app existing yet.

Store (`/store`). "First arrivals" strip of 6-8 craftsman objects with Monolise research trip photography. Each card: 4:5 portrait object photo, craftsman name (12px uppercase), object name (18-20px EB Garamond), one-sentence description. Uses `StripReveal` for the reveal pattern.

7. Meet Auwa cursor-follow (week of 5 May, best-effort)

SOTD signature interaction. Auwa's gaze tracks the cursor on desktop. Rieko produces 3-5 illustrated frames over the coming week. Tom implements in 1-2 hour daily slots during app-build week. If not ready by submission, ship post-submission as an Awwwards entry update; judges accept these.

8. Ongoing through June

- Rieko: craftsman shortlist + Japanese one-pager. 30-50 craftsmen, tiered.
- Newsletter "arrival" letter to existing subscribers in early May. One paragraph, one link. Warm, not promotional.
- Continue journal publishing at roughly two articles per month.
- Begin Seasonal Journey internal planning; see Seasonal Journeys section.

Phase 1 target by end of June: 2-3K IG followers, 400-600 subscribers, 12-15 published articles, Fin DAC article shipped, Awwwards submitted, all warm-network shares done, craftsman shortlist drafted, app in friends' hands.

9. Phase 2 onward (summer 2026 into 2027)

With Phase 1 targets met:

- App public release when IG has solid following.
- Guest articles pitched to two aligned publications (It's Nice That and Cereal are my picks).
- First figure edition drop via subscriber lottery (the site's bottom-strip entry teaser already seeds this).
- First Seasonal Journey trialled by Tom and Rieko alone in 2027.
- Book pre-order campaign opens once the draft is polished.

- Store soft launch with first handful of craftsmen.

Channel Strategy

Instagram: primary. Full detail in `instagram.md`. Three posts per week sustainably, with the daily restart burst for the first two to three weeks. Character Reels at around 35% weight. Editorial slideshows from journal articles. Seasonal atmospheric posts. This is where the audience is built.

LinkedIn: peer amplification. Four personal Tom posts across 18 months: restart share (now), app arrival, store opening, book release. Not a daily channel. The Auwa company page uses the locked tagline, description, and imagery.

Tom's restart post template:

"A project Rieko and I have been quietly building for ten years: Auwa, a quiet return to the Japanese belief that a life force, a kokoro, resides in all things. Illustration, writing, photography, a daily practice to come. Made with care, not a client project for once. auwa.life"

Awwwards and design recognition. Submit once the site has been live and stable with 12-15 articles up and the submission gates are green. Submit to Awwwards (£150 Pro), SiteInspire, CSS Design Awards, Typewolf, Godly, Minimal.gallery, httpster.

Guest articles (Phase 2). Pick two of: It's Nice That (most likely to land), Cereal (brand match), Apartamento, Openhouse, Kinfolk (dream, pitch after app lands), Aeon, Tokyo Weekender. One landed piece outperforms five pitched and ignored.

Organic link-building. Three to five personal emails a month in Phase 2. Subject line human, body two to three sentences, link to one specific Auwa piece, no ask. Aligned sites: Nalata Nalata, Analogue Life, Rikumo, Tortoise, Kinto, Ignant, Remodelista, Freunde von Freunden, Hole and Corner, Kyoto Journal, Tofugu.

Email outreach to niche communities (Phase 2). Japan Society UK, Daiwa Anglo-Japanese Foundation, Japan Foundation London, British Museum Japan curators, V&A Japan team, SOAS Japan Research Centre, Japan Society NYC, Japan House LA, Portland Japanese Garden, r/japantravel, r/chefknives. Each a single personalised email offering something (a piece, an event, a partnership), never a pitch.

Press: Phase 3 onward. Freelancers who have written for Wallpaper*, Monocle, Wired, Vogue Business, Dezeen.

What we don't do: TikTok, YouTube depth (apart from Shigefusa), Twitter/X, Pinterest, Threads, Facebook page as a content channel.

Footer social links policy. Only show icons for platforms that carry real content. Dead links on a premium brand site read as unfinished craft, and Awwwards judges click footer icons. Secure all handles (done), but hide each platform's footer icon until it has at least three to four pieces of content. Implement as a simple boolean per platform in a config file so icons can be turned on progressively. Current state: Instagram on, everything else off until seeded.

Budget: £2-3K across 12 months

- **Small restart boost (after 9 posts are live):** £200-400.
- **App arrival spend (autumn 2026):** £1,400-1,800.
- **Design award fees:** £150-300.
- **Newsletter growth ads:** £200-300.
- **Contingency:** £200-400.

Most of the marketing value comes from consistent content and thoughtful outreach, both free. Paid spend amplifies what's working, it doesn't create traction where there is none.

Seasonal Journeys (programme, not a pillar)

A small annual guided Japan experience for foreigners. Five people maximum, four to six days, once a year (constrained by the dog in UK and by quality).

This is not a fifth pillar. The homepage architecture stays at four (Journal, Store, App, Book). Journeys exist inside the brand as a programme that emerges naturally from Journal content and Store craftsman relationships. Public presence:

- Soft CTA at the foot of relevant journal articles (craftsman profiles, travel pieces, onsen essays).
- A `/journeys` page when the first trip is imminent. Not before.
- A Resend segment of interested names, grown quietly.

Pilot plan. Tom and Rieko do the first trip alone in 2027. Purpose: format discovery, content generation, logistics shakedown. No paying customers on the first trip. Real bookings open only after the pilot.

Why it matters commercially. At £3-4K per person, five people per trip is £15-20K at healthy margin. One trip a year funds significant chunks of annual brand costs, and the content produced (writing, photography, possibly film) seeds the following year's editorial output.

Where it connects. Craftsman outreach for the Store often overlaps with craftsmen who might welcome a small respectful annual visit. Rieko's Japanese-language outreach can open both conversations in one email where the fit is right.

Sign-up Hooks

The figure lottery is already live via the site's bottom strip ("WIN FIRST EDITION Auwa FIGURE" with Enter button linking to `/store`). Store teaser copy updated to:

"Japanese craftsman objects, and our own figure editions. Small, signed, hand-finished. Sign up for the opening, and a chance to win our first edition."

This is the primary scarcity hook. Additional hooks earn their place over time:

- **Welcome PDF on signup.** A 10-page illustrated guide, Rieko-designed. Produced once, compounds forever. Build when time allows.
- **Subscriber early access to journal articles** (48 hours ahead). Frames the newsletter as membership.
- **Hand-signed Rieko postcard** at signup to real postal addresses. One-time, gated.
- **First chapter of the book** digitally for subscribers once the book is ready.

Figure lottery + welcome PDF is the strongest combination.

Shigefusa and the first YouTube moment

Warm connection through the Kyoto knife shop owner from whom Tom bought his Shigefusa knife. Rieko drafts the ask in Japanese this week (template prepared in prior session). Posture: producer-in-service-of-artist, not journalist-taking. The film would be the gift; Auwa gets distribution permission, the shop and Shigefusa-san get full use.

If it lands: first YouTube piece, signature documentary anchor, opens craftsman doors everywhere else.

If not: playbook learned for the next master. Either outcome is useful.

No intention to carry Shigefusa in the Auwa store. He is too exclusive; forcing that ask would break the relationship.

Awwwards SOTD Submission Prep

The two SOTD additions

Meet Auwa cursor-follow (signature interaction). Full spec in the Plan section 7.

Teaser page upgrades (Book, App, Store). Full spec in the Plan sections 1 and 6.

Submission inputs (pre-drafted)

- **Title:** Auwa
- **URL:** https://auwa.life
- **Tagline (under 70 chars):** A quiet return to Japanese awareness. Kokoro in all things.
- **Short description (under 400 chars):** Auwa is a Japanese awareness brand built on the ancient belief that a life force, a kokoro, resides in all things. A character, a philosophy, a world, expressed through a journal from Japan, a daily awareness practice, a store of craftsman objects, and an illustrated world. Editorial, meditative, and photographed entirely by the founders.
- **Primary category:** Wellbeing
- **Tags:** Editorial, Typography, Animation, Transitions, Interaction Design, Cultural, Storytelling
- **Preview image (1400×787 JPG, under 1MB):** close crop of Auwa's face from the hero video.

Pre-submission polish pass

Two to three hours the day before submission. Walk through the site desktop and mobile simultaneously with fresh eyes. Look for: broken links, lazy-loaded images that blink in late, console errors, mobile menu edge cases, footer behaviour on short pages, contact email obfuscation rendering correctly, all article OG images present, audio toggle working across pages, Lenis smooth scroll not conflicting with horizontal scrollers. Full checklist in CLAUDE.md "AWWWARDS READINESS."

Decisions

App before Store. Decided. App is closer to ready, the cleaner debut product, and easier to iterate on real usage. Store craftsman outreach runs in parallel.

Book release: hybrid POD + pre-order offset. IngramSpark print-on-demand as the always-available edition (unit cost £8-15, retail £28-35, zero upfront). Pre-order campaign funds a short offset run (200-500 copies) for a signed first edition at £45-60. Pre-orders pay for the print; no capital committed upfront. Campaign opens in Phase 2 once the draft is polished and Colin's view is in.

Year 1 Success (by April 2027)

- 12-18K genuine IG followers
- 3-5K email subscribers
- App public at 500-2,000 users
- Two or three press pieces landed
- 30-50 journal articles compounding SEO
- 5-10 craftsmen onboarded
- Book pre-order campaign live or imminent
- Shigefusa film shipped or in the can
- First figure edition sold out
- Fin DAC collab landed
- Newsletter at sustainable 2x/month cadence

Slow, dignified, correct for the brand.

Year 2 Success

- 40-75K IG followers
- Store live with 20-30 craftsmen, revenue flowing
- Book shipped in two editions, reviewed somewhere aligned
- App at 5-10K users, paid tier converting
- First Seasonal Journey run (Tom and Rieko pilot)
- Second and third figure editions dropped
- YouTube channel with three to five craftsman films
- First exhibition, pop-up, or gallery moment

- Recognisable position: "the Japanese awareness brand"

Year 2 is where the brand stops being a project and becomes an institution. Year 1 earns the right to Year 2.